hugged me, throwing all her weight on me, almost screaming in excitement. A boy came and took my bag in while she pulled me inside.

'He's my little brother,' Hema said.

'Namaskara,' the little boy, whose name I couldn't catch, greeted me. I greeted him back. While her brother went inside with my luggage, Hema walked me through the house. It was a small, old-fashioned home with family pictures hanging on almost all the walls. Hema showed me her room, and we chatted for a while before she prepared two cups of coffee for the both of us. Her mother reached home by six in the evening and greeted me warmly. She began preparations for dinner at once. After almost two hours, we were all seated at the dining table. It was for the first time that Hema introduced me to her father, who had just joined us from work. Gentle in behaviour and soft-spoken, he was a medium-built man dressed in loose trousers, a shirt and sandals, sporting a thick moustache. While Hema's mother arranged mouth-watering delicacies on the dining table, Hema and I shared our SSB experience with everyone. Mirth and laughter filled the room. Traditional home-cooked food only added to the warmth and love. After a long time, I felt at home and wondered when I would be able to dine like this with my own family again.

Hema's mother woke me up the next morning. 'You must catch the six o'clock bus to reach IAM on time,' she said to me as she offered me some coffee. 'I've packed idli and gunpowder chutney for breakfast.' I hugged her at this heart-warming gesture. 'Thank you, Aunty.' She smiled and hugged me back.

Hema's mother was right about the timings. The six o'clock bus dropped me at IAM by half past seven and I was ready for my medical tests by eight. The tests were carried out and they were all done by noon. A medical board was held thirty minutes later and I was summoned to the conference hall. It was to be chaired by the commandant, with two other medical officers. When I went in, the commandant broke the first awful news to me. I had received a 'temporary rejection', or TR, for being overweight by 7 kg. But I was already prepared for this. I was given four weeks to lose the extra weight, after which I was supposed to go to the Air Force Central Medical